1.1 Lincoln Issues the Emancipation Proclamation

In a game of tug-of-war, if both sides pull with equal force, neither wins. In the summer of 1862, the Union and Confederate armies were both tugging equally, and President Lincoln had to find a way to end the standoff.

MAIN IDEA In 1863, Abraham Lincoln issued the Emancipation Proclamation, which freed slaves in states under Confederate control.

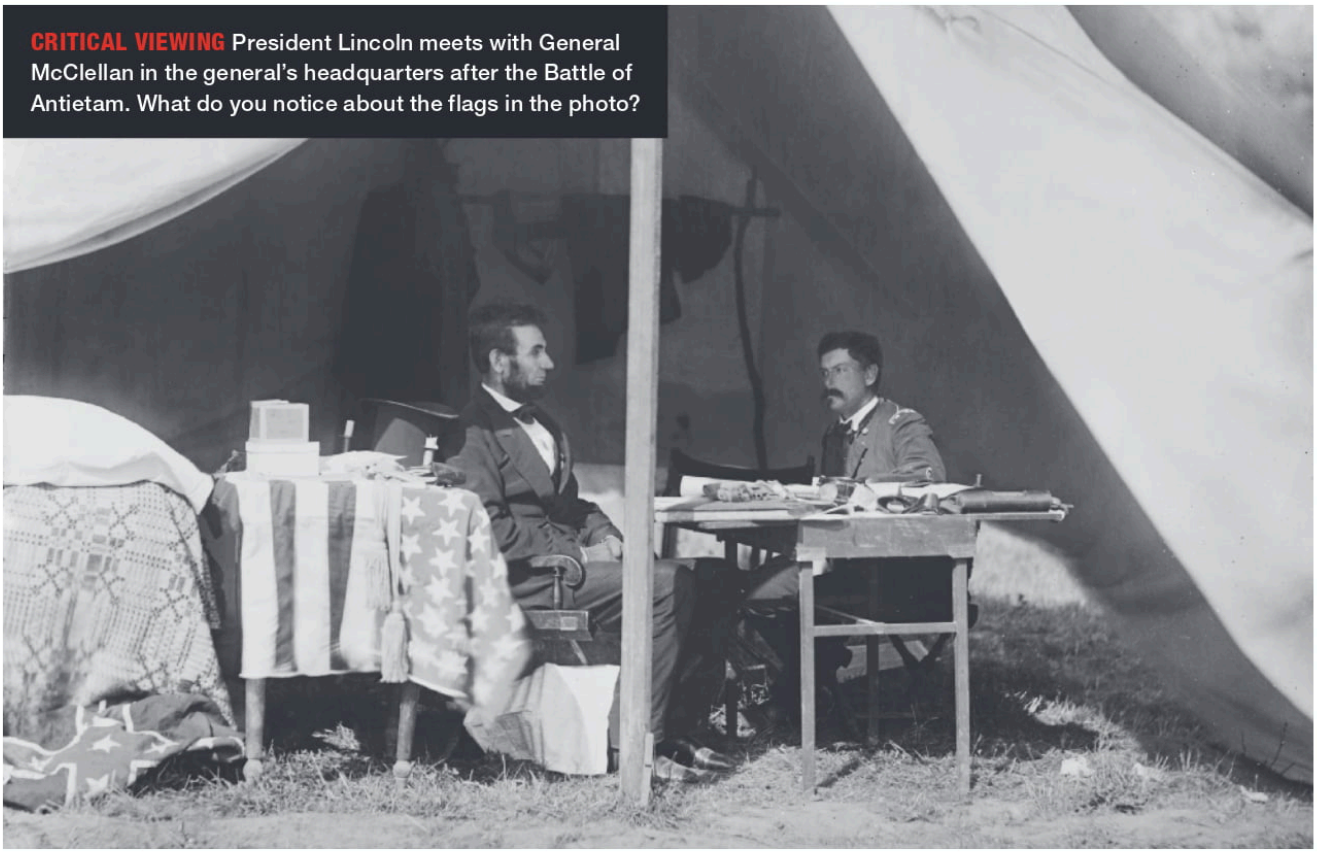
GIVING PURPOSE TO THE WAR

Before September 17, 1862, the name "Antietam" referred only to a creek near Sharpsburg, Maryland. But by sunset that day, Antietam would become the name of one of the bloodiest battles ever fought on American soil. Despite battle after battle, the war had reached a **stalemate**, with neither side holding a clear path to a final victory. And still, the body count rose.

In both the North and the South, the loss of so many lives led many to question why Americans were fighting against one another. In the midst of all this suffering, President Lincoln sought to define a greater moral purpose for the war. He realized the Union could not defeat the Confederacy without first destroying slavery.

From the beginning of the war, President Lincoln had faced pressure from abolitionists to end slavery. Although personally opposed to the

CRITICAL VIEWING President Lincoln meets with General McClellan in the general's headquarters after the Battle of Antietam. What do you notice about the flags in the photo?



Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

PRIMARY SOURCE

That on the first day of January, in the year of our Lord one thousand eight hundred and sixty-three, all persons held as slaves within any State or designated part of a State, the people whereof shall then be in rebellion against the United States, shall be then, thenceforward, and forever free.

—from the Emancipation Proclamation, issued by Abraham Lincoln, January 1, 1863

institution, Lincoln was initially reluctant to abolish it outright. Instead, he envisioned a gradual end to slavery, with slaveholders being paid for the loss of their property. Northern Democrats, whose support he needed, opposed abolition. Many of them were sympathetic to the South and to the cause of slavery, even as they remained loyal to the Union. They warned Lincoln against the social, economic, and political fallout of bringing an end to slavery, whether slowly or abruptly.

From a military standpoint, however, the institution of slavery gave the Confederacy an advantage over the Union. Slave labor kept the southern agrarian economy running, which meant more white southern men could join the Confederate Army. Although some members of Lincoln's party urged him to allow African-American men to fight on the side of the Union, the president remained hesitant to offend the border states by doing so. By the summer of 1862, Union troops had secured the slave-owning states of Missouri and Kentucky.

FOREVER FREE

The North had been fighting to preserve the Union, but a clearer moral purpose was emerging from the bloodshed. Five days after the Union victory at Antietam, Lincoln shifted the focus of the war. He issued a decree that emancipated, or freed, all Confederate slaves. Lincoln had purposely waited to submit a draft of the **Emancipation Proclamation** to his cabinet because he knew the timing had to be right for such a dramatic move. The five-page document declared that all slaves in rebel states were "thenceforward, and forever free." It committed the government and armed forces of the United States to liberate enslaved people in rebel states. The final draft of the proclamation allowed the Union to accept freed slaves into its fighting forces. On January 1, 1863, Lincoln formally issued the Emancipation Proclamation.

At the time Lincoln wrote the proclamation, approximately 4 million enslaved people lived in the United States. However, the proclamation did not apply to slaves in the Union's slave-holding border states of Maryland, Missouri, Kentucky, Delaware, or West Virginia. Lincoln feared that emancipating slaves in all Union-controlled territories might cause border states to join the Confederacy. The Union couldn't afford that loss.

As you have read, the Declaration of Independence states that "all men are created equal." However, according to the Constitution, enslaved African Americans were not equal citizens with equal rights. By issuing the Emancipation Proclamation, Lincoln began the long process of addressing the vast discrepancies between the words of the Declaration of Independence and the realities experienced by African Americans, both enslaved and free.

Slaveholders in Confederate states did not consider themselves bound by U.S. law, and they refused to acknowledge the proclamation. In order to become free, enslaved people still had to escape to Union-controlled territory. About 500,000 African Americans emancipated themselves by escaping. Some young men who did so fled to Union camps and, after 1863, even joined the Union Army. However, many enslaved people in the South knew nothing about the Emancipation Proclamation until the war was over.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the goals of the Emancipation Proclamation?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** To what extent did the Emancipation Proclamation extend the principles of the Declaration of Independence?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What factors affected President Lincoln's decision to issue the Emancipation Proclamation?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.